

Data Collection Report: Mobile Money Usage in Cameroon

1. Overview

This project set out to understand how mobile money is actually used in Cameroon, with a focus on MTN MoMo and Orange Money. Rather than relying only on platform-level assumptions, the study collected first-hand transaction records and demographic information from real users across different cities, occupations, and income levels.

The goal was not statistical generalization. With a small sample, the priority was to collect rich, trustworthy, and ethically obtained data that could support exploratory analysis and later modeling. For that reason, purposive sampling was used instead of random sampling.

2. Purpose of the Collection

Mobile money has become a major part of everyday financial life in Cameroon. People use it to send money, receive payments, save temporarily, pay for services, and manage day-to-day transactions. This project aimed to capture that behavior in a way that reflects real diversity in usage patterns.

The collection was designed to answer a simple question: who is using mobile money, how are they using it, and what social and economic factors help explain those patterns?

3. Sampling Strategy

Because the project involved only 10 participants, random sampling would likely have produced a narrow and repetitive group. Instead, purposive sampling was used to deliberately include variation across key dimensions:

- Age
- Gender
- Profession
- Income level
- Household size
- Geographic location

This approach helped ensure that the dataset included users whose behavior might differ meaningfully from one another. The participants came from Yaounde, Bamenda, and Douala, which also helped reduce overreliance on a single local network.

The final participant pool included university students, traders, retirees, and public servants, with ages ranging from 18 to 55+ and household sizes from 1 to 9. Monthly incomes ranged from under 50,000 FCFA to above 400,000 FCFA.

4. Data Collected

Each participant was asked to provide two types of information:

- 10 mobile money transaction records
- A short demographic questionnaire

The transaction records gave insight into real usage behavior, while the questionnaire provided context for interpreting those transactions. Together, they made it possible to connect financial activity with age group, occupation, location, and household situation.

Before any analysis began, every record was anonymized. Personal identifiers were replaced with anonymous user IDs, and sensitive details were removed from the analysis dataset.

5. Ethical Process

Ethics were treated as a core part of the data collection process, not an afterthought.

Each participant was first briefed on the purpose of the project. They were told what data would be collected, how it would be used, and that participation was entirely voluntary. A consent form was signed before any data was shared.

This process mattered because mobile money data is personal. Transaction histories can reveal habits, income patterns, family support behavior, and spending priorities. For that reason, the project used anonymization and consent from the start.

The ethical steps followed were:

- Explain the purpose of the project clearly
- Request voluntary participation
- Collect signed consent
- Remove identity information
- Replace names and sensitive identifiers with anonymous labels
- Begin analysis only after anonymization was complete

6. Collection Challenges

The collection process was not straightforward, and the difficulties were part of the learning experience.

Trust and Participation

The biggest challenge was trust. Many people understandably considered their mobile money history private and were unwilling to share it. Several potential participants declined, and that hesitation was appropriate. The process

reinforced the idea that ethical data collection depends on cooperation, not pressure.

Network Bias

Most of the available personal contacts were in Yaounde, which created an immediate sampling bias. Reaching people in Bamenda and Douala required secondary connections. That made the sample broader geographically, but it also showed how easily a dataset can mirror the researcher’s social network before it mirrors the wider population.

Inconsistent Data Formats

Participants did not always share their information in the same format. Some sent screenshots instead of direct exports, which required careful manual transcription. This slowed the process and increased the need for validation, but it also highlighted a common fieldwork reality: real-world data is often messy before it becomes usable.

7. What the Process Revealed

The collection phase itself produced several important lessons.

First, ethical data collection is slow by design. Time spent building trust, explaining the project, and documenting consent is not wasted time; it is what makes the data credible.

Second, network bias is real and easy to underestimate. A researcher’s social circle can strongly shape who gets included, especially when recruitment is informal. Recognizing that early helped improve the diversity of the sample.

Third, a small, carefully collected dataset is more valuable than a large dataset with weak provenance. In this project, every participant was known, every consent form was signed, and every identity was anonymized before analysis. That gave the data a level of integrity that would have been impossible to achieve through speed alone.

8. Conclusion

This data collection exercise produced a compact but ethically sound dataset on mobile money usage in Cameroon. Although the sample size is small, it captures meaningful variation across location, age, profession, income, and household structure. The process also demonstrated that good data collection is not only about quantity; it is about care, consent, and representativeness.

The most important takeaway is simple: small, well-collected data is better than large, careless data. In this project, the time invested in trust, documentation, and anonymization is what makes the dataset worth analyzing.

9. Summary of Key Lessons

- Mobile money data is personal and requires trust-based collection.
- Purposive sampling was more appropriate than random sampling for a 10-participant study.
- Geographic and social network bias shaped the recruitment process.
- Manual data transcription was necessary in some cases because not all participants used the same export format.
- Ethical handling, consent, and anonymization are essential for credible analysis.
- A small dataset can still be meaningful if it is carefully collected and well documented.

End of report.